

FAIRWAY OF PROMISE

India's young golfers showed glimpses of their **potential** as Shannon Tan overcame a tense final round to win the Hero Women's Indian Open.

Twist in the tale: Shannon Tan, who started the final round seven shots off the lead, won the title in the most dramatic way possible. LADIES EUROPEAN TOUR

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For a brief while, it looked like the drought of a home winner at the Hero Women's Indian Open golf would finally be over. In the 17 seasons of its existence, the marquee event of the sport in the country has only had one Indian lifting the trophy.

That it did not happen, and Hitaashee Bakshi (**facing page, above-right**) faltered when it mattered most on a dramatic final day that saw hold-ups, swinging fortunes and unexpected results.

With close to 120 golfers from 31 countries in action over four days in the middle of an unexpectedly clear October, the tournament has come a long way from its humble beginnings. In many ways, it mirrors the growth of women's golf in a country that continues to see it, along with a few other sports, as the domain of the privileged.

"We started the Women's Golf Association of India in 2004 as Champika Sayal's brainchild to have a professional tour for women in the country. We had some great players like Anjani Desai and Nonita Lall Qureshi, but they were amateurs; it wasn't possible for them to carry on playing and make an income out of the sport. We started with four to five girls, putting in ₹10,000 each, along with Satish Tandon, who was our first president, to get it off the ground. The first Indian Open was in 2007," WGAI president Kavita Singh told *Sportstar*.

From 79 entries back then with a prize purse of \$100,000, the event has grown into a \$500,000 tournament this time around. From only being an Asian event to being co-sanctioned by the LET (in 2010) and drawing entries from all the top European nations, it's been a steady rise for the event and for women's golf. The inclusion of the sport in the Olympics has helped increase its visibility and, more importantly, ensured that it is taken seriously as a sport.

Back then, India's top golfer Smriti Mehra